construction of a hill station began, which was named Darjeeling after a local monastery called Dorjeling (‘the place of the thunderbolt’) in Tibetan. More land was obtained after conflicts between the chogyal and the British —and, more importantly, between the British and the neighbouring state of Bhutan. By the early 1860s, the entire area of what today constitutes Darjeeling District of West Bengal was in British hands, including the important trading town of Kalimpong.

Under yet another treaty, this time signed in Tumlong in March 1861 between Sidkeong Namgyal, the chogyal, and Sir Ashley Eden representing the British, what remained of Sikkim became a de facto British protectorate. Subsequent civil and ecclesiastical friction, an invasion by Tibetan forces, and claims of Chinese suzerainty over Sikkim prompted the British Crown to annex the entire kingdom more formally as a protectorate in 1889.[7] A road and even a railway were built to Darjeeling, connecting the area with Calcutta, the capital of Britain’s Indian Empire. Tea was introduced to the highlands and even to the plains below.

John Claude White, a British engineer, photographer, and later, author, became the first political officer for Sikkim, and, the first political officer for Sikkim residing in Gangtok. He had a magnificent mansion built, from where he reorganized the administration and chaired the council that advised the chogyal. That building is what became India House after 1947 and today serves as the residence of the governor.

Under British rule, Sikkim had a status similar to that of the other princely states and the ruler came to be referred to as ‘maharaja’, not ‘chogyal’. The official India Office List names Sikkim as a 15-gun salute state along with 17 other principalities, among them Jaisalmer, Alwar, Kishangarh, Rampur—and Bhutan, which was also included in the dependencies of Britain’s Indian Empire. But Sikkim was a frontier state, which the British treated somewhat differently from the other princely states.

The immediate problem after 1889 was that Sikkim was under-populated for Britain’s designs for the region. It only had about 30,000 inhabitants, and manpower was needed for the construction of roads and portering of goods.[8] But there was a simple solution to that: the importation of labour from Nepal. According to Nari Rustomji, the Indian civil servant with perhaps the strongest attachment to the northern frontier areas, ‘While